



Facilitating the Indian electronics industry

Ajai has been at the forefront in helping create the electronics industry in India. He has been involved in government committees since 1999. In 2009, he headed a task force created by MeitY (the Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology), which made path-breaking recommendations where the task force warned that the electronics import bill will exceed the oil import bill. This formed the basis of the Electronics Policy.

In 2011, in recognition of helping build the IT and electronics industry in India, the Hon'ble President of India conferred him the prestigious Padma Bhushan award, one of the highest civilian honours in India. He has received many awards, including EFY's Electronics Man of the Year 2010, CNBC's India Innovation of the Year Award 2010, and Cybermedia Business ICT Award 2013 for Lifetime Achievement in ICT.

Ajai has been an institution builder and has chaired IIT Hyderabad and IIIT-Naya Raipur and helped build these two institutions from their founding. And then, he chaired IIT Patna during its early days. In addition, he was Chairman of NIFFT Ranchi and helped convert the institute to the National Institute of Advanced Manufacturing with the change of course towards Industry 4.0. Ajai was also the Founding Chairman of the Electronics Sector Skills Council of India.

Since 2011, Ajai has been deeply

"I always believed in giving back to society, so I have set up a charitable trust, called Swayam, where we contribute to many areas, including education, women empowerment, poverty alleviation, and provided relief during Covid to Delhi and Goa citizens. I am also a Board Member of Population Foundation of India, a Trustee of Save Life Foundation, and Founding Angel of Nudge Foundation." — **Ajai Chowdhry**

Some of My Favourite Things

Favourite actor: Dev Anand

Favourite actress: Sadhna

Favourite music: Music is my passion. I love singing and old Bollywood music

Favourite food: Chinese food

Favourite film: Guide

Favourite pastimes: Reading books, singing, and watching movies

Favourite book: I read all kinds of books, both fiction and non-fiction. At present, I am reading a great book called The Great Tech Game.

involved in investing in, nurturing, and mentoring startups. He is on the board of the largest angel network in India, Indian Angel Network, and has personally invested in more than 70 startups. He is on the Investment Committee of the IAN Fund, Electronic Development Fund, and Canbank Venture Capital Fund. He is also the Chairman of the FICCI Startup Committee.

Ajai has been nominated by MeitY as a Member of the Advisory Board of India Semiconductor Mission. He has been appointed as an Esteemed Member of the Consultation Group on Science & Technology and Innovation Sector by the Vice-Chairman of Niti Aayog.

In 2021, Ajai co-founded EPIC Foundation, an industry-led non-profit organisation conceived to develop electronics products of national importance. It aims to unleash an economic potential of 20 billion dollars and self-empower the masses of India by bridging the digital divide and creating a secure technology infrastructure. He is currently the Chairman of EPIC Foundation and has created a fabulous team of more than 50 eminent global advisors to provide impetus to this important national initiative.

Nurturing life with family and music

Ajai began his family life simultaneously with his journey at HCL. He got married in 1977 after meeting his wife, Kunkun Chowdhry, for the first time at Shiv Nadar's house.

She is a cousin of Shiv Nadar's wife, Guddu.

Ajai and Kunkun have two sons, Kunal and Akshay. Their elder son, Kunal, is an entrepreneur with strong academic background, and the younger one, Akshay, has chosen music as his career. While sharing a few memorable family moments, Ajai narrates, "My family fantastically celebrated my 70th birthday in Goa. My wife created a beautiful coffee table book on my life. My son and grandchildren conceptualised and performed a musical show for me."

In addition to living a happy family life, Ajai continues nurturing his passion for music. From jazz to old Hindi film songs, and from old western numbers to Indian classical, he has a varied playlist. While his all-time favourite Hindi film singers are the two legends, Kishore Kumar and Mohammad Rafi, he is also quite fond of the jazz idols, George Benson and Earl Klugh.

The marriage contributed more melodies to Ajai's life as his wife Kunkun is the granddaughter of renowned Naina Devi, often regarded as India's Thumri queen. Ajai says, "Some of my taste in classical music also got influenced by my wife." In Hindustani classical music, he is mesmerised by Kishori Amonkar's voice.

Ajai is actively involved in the musical community named Luttf. As a part of the community, he performs regularly and participates in theme-based musical rendezvous every week. **EFY**